

Can Only You Hear Me Now?

Another point of contention over VoIP is that of security. In essence, a VoIP service is based on data packets. When you consider that sniffing of data packets is a very real security problem on the Internet, it is clear that your voice calls can fall to the same tools and hacks used. The thought of a competitor listening in to your VoIP calls using packet sniffing tools is quite real here. However, two things need to be considered as far as security is concerned. Firstly, if a determined competitor is indeed involved, even a traditional phone is open to wire-tapping. Secondly, it is possible to establish a secure line over the Internet with the help of encryption. Encryption is an essential tool if you do commerce over the Internet, and its efficiency can be, and is, extended to VoIP.

Fortunately, there are many VoIP-encryption products available. Skype has built-in encryption. Phil Zimmermann of Pretty Good Privacy (PGP) fame has recently released a beta tool dubbed Zfone (www.philzimmermann.com/EN/zfone/index.html), an open source product for enabling VoIP security. At the time of writing, Zfone is only available for the Linux and Mac platforms, with Windows availability targeted at mid-April 2006. Moreover, VoIP security is a very visible problem one that companies small and big are aiming to resolve. You can learn more about current and future initiatives at the VoIP Security Alliance www.voipsa.org.

A final note of caution can be made in regards to fly-by-night VoIP providers. Although you can set up a VoIP service yourself, with the basic

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amenities available, some ISPs also provide it as part of a data or service package. But as VoIP gains acceptance, small operators are bound to mushroom, and one needs to be chary of subscribing to their services they might well disappear overnight!

Making The Call

In India, as per TRAI regulation, you can establish a PC-to-PC call anywhere in the world both within and outside India. However, a PC-to-phone connection can only be established between India and a foreign country. TRAI also puts forth certain QoS requirements for VoIP providers. Note that convergence of VoIP with traditional landlines or cellular phone lines is not yet allowed in India: as such, you cannot legally use VoIP to call a landline or a cell phone.

For a business in India, then, there are two options: you can use VoIP to make substantially cheaper international calls, and you can use VoIP to make calls to a national branch. While the former can be either computer-to-computer or computer-to-phone, the latter can only be between two personal computers. Additionally, if your company has a large local network, it can deploy a VoIP solution across it.

The common element here would be a good connection to the Internet. As a rule of thumb, avoid ISPs that connect you via a satellite link; the latencies involved would make for a not-so-great voice connection. Try to stick to providers that connect via undersea cables instead. Some ISPs offer VoIP as separate services; test these

Using Skype

Skype is the leading VoIP software. Apart from PC-to-PC and PC-to-phone calls, it also allows for large file transfers and text chat. It also automatically encrypts all outgoing data, be it voice or file transfers. This little workshop will take you through the installation and use of the Skype software.

1 STEP Download Skype
The latest version of this software also allows for video calls if you have a Web camera. Head to www.skype.com to download it.

2 STEP Set up your username
Double-click on the downloaded file to start the installation process. After Skype installs, you need to create a profile on the Skype service. The username you supply here must be unique, similar to your MSN or Yahoo! ID. Later on, you can add contacts using this username.

3 STEP Adding contacts
Skype can automatically add contacts by searching your address books, including those in Outlook and Opera. Allowing the setup program to do this is a good idea. The



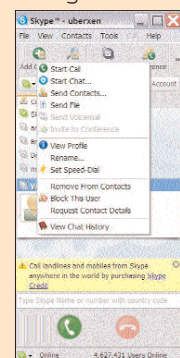
Skype will automatically search your address book for contacts with Skype

software will now determine which of your contacts has a Skype account, based on their e-mail address. Follow this step to its end to add contacts with Skype, or to send a request to your contacts to install Skype and register on its network.

4 STEP Making calls
Once a contact has accepted your request, you will be able to place a call to him. Click on the green Call button to make a call; the red button will hang up. Note that you can directly type in a contact's name or phone number in the address field above these icons. To the right of the Contactstab is the Dial section, which offers a traditional dial-pad; to its left is where Skype keeps a history of your outgoing and incoming VoIP calls.

Note that you can start a traditional chat session, transfer files, and set a speed dial by right-clicking on a contact.

5 STEP Calling a phone line
While PC-to-PC Skype calls are free, you need to pay to place calls to a phone line or to a mobile phone. This service is called SkypeOut, and requires that you buy credit from Skype. It is like a pre-paid cell phone account. To check the rates applied per minute, head to www.skype.com/products/skypeout/rates/



Apart from voice calls, you can use Skype to text chat and transfer files